Communications Checklist for Change Management

Use preferred senders to deliver communications in your organization

Employees prefer to hear messages from senior leaders for organizational messages about change (i.e., business reasons) and from people managers for the personal impacts.

Prepare and equip preferred senders to effectively deliver communications

In addition to coaching preferred senders to communicate messages effectively, you need to facilitate communications by drafting messages, ensuring consistency among senders, and sequencing and scheduling delivery.

Ensure that preferred senders answer the right questions first

When people learn about a change, their first question is, "Why is this happening?"
The first communications about a change should always focus on:
1) why the change is happening, 2) why it's happening now, and 3) the risk of not changing.

Next, answer the WIIFM question

WIIFM stands for "What's in it for me?" It's a question people always ask during change, even when the change seems positive. Because making a change is a personal choice, communications only resonate with the impacted individuals if you address what they care about.

Preferred senders should repeat key messages five to seven times

Having the preferred senders repeat key messages ensures that the messages you want to communicate get heard by your audience as you intended.

Resist the urge to communicate exclusively through the project team

Remember that people have preferred senders of messages. One of the biggest and most common mistakes you can make is to have your project team send all the communications.

Find effective ways to reach your audience

An effective communications plan uses numerous channels such as virtual or in-person meetings, small group forums, one-on-one conversations, newsletters, presentations, brainstorming workshops, focus groups, lunch and learns, intranet Q&A forums, screen-saver messages, etc.

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Emphasize face-to-face communications

While it is time intensive to meet with someone live—either in person or virtually—the effort delivers far more value than an email message.

Create opportunities for two-way communications

Two-way communications lead to greater support for change, so your communications plan needs to include them. For example, create small-group forums where participants share concerns and feedback, and can ask questions of senior leaders in real time.

Evaluate the effectiveness of your communication messages

To understand if your audience is hearing and properly interpreting the messages you send, use a combination of post-communication surveys, focus groups, and individual interviews to assess effectiveness, and then take adaptive actions if necessary.

Ready for the Next Step in Your Change Management Journey?

Elevate your change management communications by attending a Prosci Change Management Certification Program. During this three-day experiential program, you learn to apply the Prosci Methodology, which includes effective communications planning.

If you're already Prosci certified, you can attend Improve Project Health, a one-day, deep-dive program to develop advanced skills that enhance your practice and professional growth while improving project outcomes.

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